When Wyrril was younger, there had been a time when they travelled with their mother to a town past the mires to sell wood carvings. They had sat in the back of the wagon, bundled in a blanket propped against the honeytree-hued totem that their father had spent months trying to perfect. Their hands traced along the meticulous etches and dentures that spoke of his hours spent arguing about the necessity of salt-soaking the irregularly hardened wood before shaping, the days where he had not eaten, choked on the fervour of his hereditary insistence of exploration, identities, and I am not doing what is easy because we are Sigtambers and I will not make our family content to lay down in the mud as their mother talked loudly over the rattle of wheel on gravel to one of their siblings making sure that the arrowshafts and tenon wood were all bundled together properly with the right hitches because last time they had come this far for this long Sariel hadn't tightened the batches properly and when the wood had spilled out onto the road behind them they had to stop and collect and rebundle them all again.
Wyrril still felt the nicks of gravel in the flesh of their knee from being stooped to the road retrieving the same fragile joints of mangrove they had watched their father cut time and time again, limbs pulled in all directions like a spider, delicate and intent, flayed like a star as he balanced on those birdcage roots and brought handsaw to wilting branch, one foot trepidatious on the bow of their canoe, as if placing any more of his even then already slender weight on the boat would tip it and send him and his two children falling into the waiting stillness of the swamp, as if their divide between human and swamp-beast would shatter, the thin membrane that upheld their identity as man would finally betray them manifest in the sable depths that waited below their boat, neither waiting for but neither objecting to their fall.
Wyrril hated falling in because it was always so quiet when their body was pulled in and the water barely reacted but for small ripples in the perfect black of the swamp, in neat light oscillations as Wyrril's body was gripped and clamped with primeval terror, the amygladic shock of the water sinching their muscles into inactivity and when the water passed over their eyes it felt like they had never truly existed and a macrocosmic ribcage had closed around them and they would sink below the water and cease to be anything and the small dancing ripples on the surface would eventually dance away to the still and dead swamp as

Sariel resurfaced, the water erupting into white noise as Wyrril gripped tighter onto the sides of the canoe, reflexively firing out a hand to meet Sariel's, and dragging their shaking form back onto the boat, the canoe a metronome in its restless swings as the water of the swamp spilled onto the ships sleek surface, colouring the painting pallet wood a stained black in spluttered clumps.
"We have to go further north."
Wyrril watched a tendril of water run down their brother's face as he choked out the words between gasps, their eyes following the tear as it moistened the pallid scales on the side of his face that pulled the skin from cheek to nose taught and stiff like boar fur on a hide stretcher (and when they had first started growing almost a decade ago Wyrril had laughed and said what is wrong with you and their father had struck them on the side of the head and dragged Wyrril out to the old stagnant pond behind their house and had talked to them for three long hours and then several months later Wyrril first saw the chitin-hard mossy lumps that had started growing on the back of their own hand).
"We should get papa to help," is what Wyrril wanted to say, "because he knows this swamp, and he's saved your life before and I don't see why he can't do it again" because last week when Sariel had first stood by their bed in the middle of night panting and shivering and said "I keep dreaming of the sleeper" that we had only dreamed of when we were both very young, and you said it was our guardian angel that would make me grow big and strong and cure grandpapa of his cough (and grandpapa had died the next winter and now Wyrril had grown claws on their left hand), and we would carve its image onto the big mangroves near where we lived and mama said you have to be careful of giving dreams flesh because sometimes there is a reason why they are not tangible in this world. Wyrril wanted to say to their brother that if the sleeper had crawled out of their dreams into

the swamp, and curled up like a ruin in the loam deep below the water, they themselves would not enough to wake it up because Wyrril was the one who first said that it was so much and so old, with ashy forests imbedded in its back and the sun in its eyes, and even though Wyrril had never told their brother they always thought that it must have been dormant and resting for so long that its eyelids would crack and fracture when opened and it must have dreamed so much for so long that they were probably the ones that had been dreamed into life by the sleeper rather than the other way around. But Wyrril nodded and gripped the oar by their legs tighter as Sariel turned away.

And, as Wyrril remembered, when they had picked up all the wood on the road to the market in the village away from the swamp, and Wyrril and Sariel had spent hours wrapping all the bundles up with the brackish green string their grandmother weaved, they had made it to the town without any of the dark mangroves or soft, porous mud that welcomed the weight of Wyrril's feet their mother had parked the cart in the town square and Sariel felt so ashamed of his patch of scales (the same Sariel that was now stood in front of Wyrril, stood with an oar barefoot and barechested with the technicoloured patterns that danced down his sharpened spine, just barely reflecting the very first inch of sunrise that threatened to reveal the two of them to the world, because then Wyrril thought and believed that they were doing something very very wrong and it wouldn't be for decades after when one night bundled like firewood in their bed they finally realized that *maybe* they had not been acting of their own freedom, that they were not truly Wyrril Sigtamber and Sariel Sigtamber but rather akin or at least adjacent to natural laws, fulfilling out the simple truths that was written in their flesh and plasma to fulfil, as certain as the tree frogs rattled and the cicadas cried and as certain as a Sigtamber was to live before feeling and they were like ivory figurepieces being dragged through the mud) that he had refused to leave the cart, so Wyrril and their mother only had sold their wares for the day. When their mother had stopped to lie down for a moment, Wyrril had gone to buy her a small medicinal remedy from the old lady across the marketplace who always called Wyrril darling, and as they went they had seen the train tracks for the first time, newly lain cast iron in gleaming and imperial decadence. But now, as their boat split the mire in its death-adjacent march, a (at the very least authentic if not fateful) walk from their home and family to the deathbed and resting place of something neither sibling would ever truly see nor grasp, if one were to see them from the view of the stolidly gliding herons above them as the sun rose they would see the siblings cusped in a virid, skeletal grasp, with crooked branches for bulged knuckles, and in its corralled hands cupping the necrotic emulsion, the virescence of life given form in the swamp, in the muck above and below the waters.
But there in the centre of the hands as both the needle and the eye and the thread therein Sariel cried out, his legs giving out like bluejoint as his body broke into jerking convulsions, and Wyrril was moving then as they grabbed their brother, shouting and asking if he was okay and part knowing the answer because they could feel it too, like a sharpened finger probing and impaling through their mind or lobes or whatever was inside their head, and Wyrril knew that they had made it and Sariel must have known too because he was shaking and laughing and as the sun began to ascend past the watching trees the light refracted his tears a golden Midas, singing down his skin and his scales

then the first horn cried out, immanent and ancient as if from angels sat perched and poised astride divine thrones but Wyrril knew that this was not a God in the sense of something held precious and loving in churches of stone and prayer, but this was a being or God or something in the way their father had spent nights hunched weeping and shaking before a totem carved of his very own spasming neurons, the way he had meticulously carved eyes and teeth and villi in the organic medium, in the *chk-chk-chk* of chisel on wood that now pounded in the back of Wyrrils head, like a heartbeat made of reed and root and rage, the screaming chugging of the black metal truth that had

stormed down the railway that day when Wyrril was younger, how it had bore down on the town, final and immanent and iron, and Wyrril was not the only one had screamed and run when they saw the creature which spewed black smoke from its mouth cascading towards the village, and now Wyrril's open mouth was hedgeseed as Sariel started retching crimson saltwater from somewhere deep within his own core, his mouth contorting into a bracken grin as the surface of the water bulged and rippled, the swamp-surface pulling tight like pasty skin in resistance the juvenile, exploratory breach of the train-beast-sleeper-thing that shook under the water, and as the second echoing wail flung through the water the boat jerked to its side as Wyrril gripped tighter to the canoe and Sariel did not, his shaking body gliding, like skipping stones with their parents when they were younger, into the bubbling surface of the swamp, and was gone. And Wyrril had never *truly* been scared of what was in the marsh, because when they had first fallen in all that time ago and the ribcage had held and pressed their body and eyes, they had felt some kind of fish or seaweed or hand caressing their bare leg, and Wyrril had never known if it was inanimate or animate, intention or habitual, brother or self, but as their father had grabbed their sodden clothes and in one single, powerful pull shot Wyrrils body out of the water, Wyrril had not been scared because the things in the marsh were like the Sigtambers – hungry and breathing and teeth so equitably physical but here, as the third song pounded through the fingers of the marsh and Wyrril was certain that they were not going to die but rather become something much worse, because in shaken violent dreams where the sides of Wyrril's head were chiselled shaped and contorted into ridicule, headaches of ochre shades that cried *end end end end end and end Wyrril, we are the end of a long line of people who have are you listening to me (and they had tried, but their head still hurt from where he had hit them but they tried not to cry and listen to their father) Wyrril a long line of survivors, who learned not to bend the fens and marsh to their will because it is not our right and we will be punished (and Wyrril thought of the now dead Reedfetters who had tried to) stop crying we are of the swamp and we will return into the swamp when we are done here. It has lent us flesh and folly to carve our own legacies, like a universe that breeds life viscerally for it to transiently recognise itself in a mirror also contorted of the universe for just an instant before immediately being dragged to the same yelling nauseous primordial flesh we grew from, and if we are only for an instant to live in this mud and moss Wyrril Wyrril if we are only for an instant I will not spend that time living in fear*

and as Sariel breached the swamp, the black water flirted like auroras in the haze, in the indeterminate hues that Wyrril could not make red from reed, could not tell the septic greens from their own hands and warping fingers and voice both tinny and forever as "sariel get out the water" moulded to scream as the swamp rose and swallowed Sariel whole, the steam engine given will and want and hunger in the grey mountainous flesh that breached the water, an open, toothed hole that swallowed son and sun and saltwater and sense in a single engulfing truth, and Wyrril was consumed in the shadow of the beast, and the fetid steam-smoke that rose off in heated breaths off its fevered skin, and Wyrril could see no perfect iron tracks or driving conductor to push the beast save the few stars that still hung painted in the skies civil dawn, that remained still and true and indifferent as Wyrril's brother was killed.

And as the beast's arc into the air zenithed, and its form returned to the pantingly indifferent water, Wyrril saw, just for that instant, the brilliant stars emblazoned in its sunken eyes, bored through with certain, oscillatory black rings, and the mossed biomass grafted, grown, intrinsic to the beast, twig and mud and swamp lodged firmly in its egregious form, before the roaring white water rose to return the creatures form whole to the waters, and the train or monster or god returned to the swamp, as huge, convulsing waves crashed against the trees, the roots, the boat, before slowly returning to stillness.

And Wyrril, sat on the gently swaying boat as its stumbling momentum dissipated back to calmness, could not stop thinking *Whatever happened to Sariel was physical and tangible and it was teeth and breathing* and therefore *whatever is in these swamps did not take Sariel for sustenance because it is dream and would not eat on flesh* and therefore *that was not what we came to find not truly* but *that was still no ordinary beast because my father never told me of trains in the* riverwater and therefore *i was not eaten because i was not meant to be eaten* and therefore *Sariel is dead but i think i am the one being fed upon.*

And Wyrril could not help but feel fear.